

So you're thinking about psychology

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Psychology produced the strangest result in the whole index.

A licensed clinical psychologist scores **3.5** out of 10 — one of the safest careers we measured.

A psychology degree with nothing after it scores **7.1**.

Same degree. A 3.6-point gap — the biggest we found between two destinations from one starting point.

The 60-second version

- If you become a licensed therapist or psychologist, you're in one of the safest careers there is.
 - About 14% of psychology graduates go on to graduate study in psychology.
 - The path to licensure is six to eight years, much of it low-paid.
 - The real question isn't "is psychology safe." It's "will I finish?"
 - And there's one alternative almost nobody mentions.
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Why the licensed end is so protected

Four reasons, and one of them is unusual.

You can't automate being someone a person trusts. In most jobs the relationship helps you deliver the service. In therapy the relationship is the treatment. That's a genuine structural difference and we rate it the highest of any career in the index.

Someone has to be accountable. When a client is at risk, a licensed human carries legal duty of care. No system holds that.

Every person is different. Formulation — working out why *this* person is struggling in *this* way — is genuinely novel every time.

And the law is moving in your favour. Several US states have moved to ban AI from delivering licensed therapy. That's rare. In almost every other career we score, regulation is quietly eroding around the profession. Here it's being written to protect it.

The thing we're not sure about

We'd rather tell you this than let a comfortable score sit unchallenged.

Our framework asks: **must a human legally do this work?** For therapy, yes — and that's getting stronger.

But there's a question it can't answer. **A profession can be legally protected and still shrink.**

Loads of people — probably including people you know — are already using chatbots for emotional support at 2am. That isn't therapy, it isn't regulated, and it competes with no licensed practitioner under the same rules. But if enough people who'd previously have sought professional help don't, the profession stays protected while its client base thins.

We measure whether a human is required. We can't measure how many are needed. **That's the clearest gap in our method, and psychology is where it shows.** We'll be watching waiting lists, and we'll say so if they move.

The scores

WHERE YOU END UP	SCORE
Clinical psychologist (licensed)	3.5
Counsellor / psychotherapist (licensed)	3.9
School psychologist	4.0
Research / academic	6.5
Organisational / HR-adjacent	7.0
Degree only, no licence	7.1

Look at where the line falls. **The top three need a licence. The bottom three don't. The licence is doing all the protective work.**

The number that should actually decide this

Around **14%** of psychology bachelor's holders go on to graduate study in psychology. Another 30% or so do graduate study in something else. The rest go into the general graduate job market.

That's not a failure rate — plenty of those people do well. But it means the most common outcome of a psychology degree isn't being a psychologist.

Which changes the question you should be asking:

If you're genuinely committed to the licensed path — six to eight years, graduate study plus supervised hours — psychology is an excellent choice and 3.5 is your number.

If you're not sure about graduate school, then honestly you're choosing a general degree, and you should compare it against other general degrees rather than against the career it looks like it leads to. That's the 7.1.

Neither answer is wrong at seventeen. But they need different decisions.

What we won't soften

The filter isn't academic. It's financial.

Six to eight years to licensure, and a lot of that is low-paid or unpaid supervised practice. That excludes people who can't afford several years on very little income in their twenties, which is worth being honest about now rather than discovering at 24.

Doctoral training is also genuinely competitive. Many people don't get on first time. Worth having a plan for that.

And the emotional load is constant rather than occasional. This is people in real distress, repeatedly, for decades. Not everyone gets better. Sitting with that is harder than most students expect.

Does this actually sound like you?

The trait that matters most, and it's a specific one: can you be with someone's distress without rushing to fix it?

Most people's instinct is to solve. Therapy is largely not solving. It's a real, identifiable disposition and it's hard to teach.

It also suits people who are comfortable with slow progress, who have genuine emotional stability to draw on, and who are interested in people rather than in behaviour as an abstract science.

One honest note. A lot of people come to psychology to understand their own experience. That's completely common and nothing to be embarrassed about — but on its own it isn't a durable foundation for a career, and it's worth knowing which one is driving you.

The alternative nobody mentions

If what pulls you is **working clinically with people in mental health** — rather than psychology as a subject — then look at **mental health nursing** before you commit.

Licensed clinical practice. Three to four years instead of six to eight. Paid training rather than unpaid hours. And it scores **2.8** — better than clinical psychology.

It is the most under-considered option in this entire index, and it's overlooked by exactly the people who'd be good at it.

Different job, obviously — more medical, more acute, less long-form therapy. But if the pull is the work rather than the discipline, it deserves a serious look.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **What proportion of graduates reach clinical training?** The number that matters and the one least often published. Ask directly.
 - **Is research methods compulsory?** It's what separates a psychology graduate from someone who's read about psychology.
 - **Is there placement or clinic experience built in?** Graduate applications need experience, and getting it is the real bottleneck.
 - **Where do the other 86% end up?** If they can't tell you, that's the answer.
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Two things worth doing

Get real experience with people in distress before you commit. Helpline volunteering, support work, care work. It answers the fit question faster than anything else, and it's what graduate applications want anyway.

Then find a working therapist or clinical psychologist and ask what the path actually cost — in years, money and energy — and whether they'd do it again. Ask someone who'll be honest

rather than encouraging.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates** — the Federal Reserve tracks unemployment and underemployment by major. Look psychology up yourself, then compare it with nursing.
 - **What can you actually do with a psychology bachelor's?** — where the 14% figure comes from, and a realistic account of where the degree leads.
 - **Two decades of psychology graduates and where they work** — twenty years of tracked outcomes from a state government rather than a university marketing department.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a department, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.